Extra Exercises 05 – Prompt Basics

AI Training for Beginners

Self-study training: use AI/LLMs safely in everyday life

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https://github.com/mgunthner/AI-Training

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Extra Exercises 05 – Prompt Basics

Cheatsheet: `01_cheatsheets/05_prompt_basics`

Levels: ★ Getting started · ★★ Everyday · ★★★ Challenge **Rule:** Use only invented or anonymized data. All tasks work with any AI service and on a free plan. Suggested solutions are at the end. Only look once you're done.

Task 1 ★ – Recognize the building blocks

Scenario: You see this prompt:

```
I'm inviting friends over for a barbecue on Saturday. Write a short
WhatsApp invitation. Tone: casual, use "you". At most 4 sentences,
no emojis.
```

Task: Find these building blocks in the prompt: goal/context, task, format, tone/audience, constraint. What's missing for the invitation to be directly usable?

Hint: Mark the building blocks with different colors or abbreviations.

Task 2 ★ – From vague to concrete

Scenario: These three prompts are too vague: - a) "Help me with my job application." - b) "Plan something for Saturday." - c) "Explain taxes to me."

Task: Pick two of them. For each, note three pieces of information the AI is missing, and rewrite the prompt.

Hint: Ask yourself: What do I need it for? For whom? What should the result look like? Use placeholders instead of real data.

Task 3 ★★ – One task per prompt

Scenario: This prompt tries to do too much at once:

```
Write me an invitation for the parents' evening, translate it into
↪ English,
turn it into a social media post, and also plan the schedule
for the evening.
```

Task: Split the job into numbered steps. Test two variants and compare: (1) everything in one prompt, (2) step by step in several prompts.

Hint: Watch whether anything gets short-changed or goes missing in variant 1.

Task 4 ★★ – Allow follow-up questions

Scenario: You're planning a weekend with friends but only have a rough idea.

Task: 1. Write a short prompt with your rough idea. 2. Append: "Ask me at most five follow-up questions before you start." 3. Answer the questions and have the plan created. 4. Present the same rough idea for comparison without the follow-up-question sentence.

Hint: Note which questions you hadn't thought of yourself.

Task 5 ★★★ – Three rounds to a good prompt

Scenario: Your package arrived a week late. You want the AI to write a polite complaint (all details as placeholders: "Company X", "Date Y").

Task: 1. **Round 1:** Write a short, vague prompt. 2. **Round 2:** Add goal, context, format, tone, and limits. 3. **Round 3:** Read the result and give the AI two concrete improvement requests. 4. Rate each round from 1 to 5: Fits the goal? Fits the tone? Fits the length? Directly usable?

Hint: Save the best prompt with a title and purpose in your prompt library.

Suggested solutions

Task 1: Goal/context: inviting friends over for a barbecue on Saturday. Task: write a short WhatsApp invitation. Format: at most 4 sentences. Tone/audience: casual, "you", friends. Constraint: no emojis. Missing: time, place, and what to bring. You can give these as placeholders or have the AI ask about them.

Task 2: Examples of what's missing: For a) field and industry, experience (briefly), whether a cover letter or résumé is meant. For b) who's coming, budget, indoors or outdoors. For c) which tax, for whom (employees, retirees …), how detailed. Rewritten, e.g.: "Explain in five sentences what income tax is. Audience: people starting their careers with no prior knowledge. Use an everyday example." For tax topics, verify the facts yourself.

Task 3: Possible observation: In the catch-all prompt, one part is often treated briefly or superficially. Step by step, you can check each result and improve it in a targeted way. Order: invitation, schedule, translation, post. Both variants are valid experiences. What matters is that you notice the difference.

Task 4: Typical follow-up questions: How many people? Budget? Travel? Dietary habits? With follow-up questions, the plan usually fits better because the AI doesn't have to guess. Questions you hadn't thought of yourself show the value of the sentence.

Task 5: Example for round 2:

```
Write a polite but firm complaint to Company X.
I ordered a package on Date Y. It arrived a week late.
I want an apology and a voucher.
Length: at most 120 words. Tone: factual, without accusations.
```

Typical: Round 1 is generic, round 2 is clearly more fitting, round 3 nails tone and length. The main lesson: Concrete details and revision beat a “perfect” first draft.

Next: Cheatsheet 06 (Prompt Techniques)

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